

The Great King of Tantras Called Vajra Āralī

Vajra Āralī Mahātantra Rāja Nāma · Toh 426 · Derge Kangyur

རྡོ་རྗེ་ཨ་ར་ལི་མཐོང་པོ་འཕྲུལ་ཀྱི་རྒྱལ་པོ་ཆེན་པོ་

Toh 426 in the Kangyur is a tantra known in Sanskrit as the Vajra Āralī Mahātantra Rāja and in Tibetan as Dorje Arali zhes bya ba'i rgyud kyi rgyal po chenpo, which may be rendered into English as "The Great King of Tantras Called Vajra Āralī." It belongs to the class of highest yoga tantras associated with the Hevajra cycle, as indicated by its opening homage to Hevajra and its characteristic setting in which the Blessed One dwells in the bhaga of the Perfection of Wisdom of all Tathāgatas. The text proceeds to offer instructions on ritual practice and visualization, including meditating on the syllable RE PHA at the heart and the arising of a vajra sun, all framed within the traditional tantra structure of questions posed by bodhisattvas and responses given by the Buddha to Vajrapāṇi. As a tantric scripture concerned with the generation-stage practices of Heruka and related deity yoga, it represents an important esoteric work within the Kangyur's collection of Vajrayāna teachings.

In the language of India: Vajra Āralī Mahātantra Rāja Nāma. In the language of Tibet: The Great King of Tantras Called Vajra Āralī.

Homage to Hevajra.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, was dwelling in the bhaga of the Perfection of Wisdom of all Tathāgatas. The Blessed One, knowing that many buddhas and bodhisattvas had made requests, and knowing this also by the bodhisattvas, arose from the meditative absorption of bliss and spoke thus to Vajrapāṇi.

Having washed the face with water,
having taken the medicine,
seated upon a comfortable seat,
one should perfectly accomplish Heruka.

At one's own heart, visualize the syllable RE PHA
blazing like the fire of an eon.
From that arises the vajra sun,
fully pervading all with a garland of flames.

Above that is the very syllable HŪM,
like the fire of the eon itself.

Contemplating that as a vajra,
Heruka arises from the vajra.

Having pressed down the great obstructors,
the body is smeared with ashes,
perfectly endowed with the five mudrās,
making the terrifying appear terrible.

With the radiance of indranīla sapphire,
with yellow hair of great power,
possessed of the taste of the nine dances,
he performs the dance of play,
and presses Mount Meru, the king of mountains so lofty,
down beneath the earth.

With the hand, the vajra is fully visualized,
and in the left hand a skull-cup born of a man,
perfectly endowed with the five nectars,
visualize it perfectly endowed with the five meats.

Like kunda-flower, like the moon,
like a lotus-garland necklace,
the shoulder is adorned with the khaṭvāṅga staff.

This is the first chapter, the divine chapter, from the Vajra Āraṇī.

Then all the bodhisattvas headed by Vajrapāṇi, and all the Tathāgatas headed by Akṣobhya, and all the vajra queens headed by the Perfection of Wisdom, and all the vajra yakṣas headed by Jambhala, and all the elemental spirits headed by the Lord of Power, and all the vajra sky-dwellers headed by Indra, and all the world-protectors headed by the elephant-ear, and all the hungry ghosts headed by Kundara, and all the sentient beings together with these, through that engagement of hearing the Dharma, made a request to the great Vajra Āraṇī, the lord of all Tathāgatas:

"Blessed One, what is the mantra for the torma offering?"

The Blessed One declared:

The Teacher of all the Sugatas
has fully disclosed the rites of torma.
The mudrā too, in its distinction,

accomplishes every desired aim.

With the vajra palms opened upward:
oṃ jvala jvala bhyo hūṃ phaṭ svāhā.

This itself is the great mantra,
likewise the mantra of the torma offering,
the mantra of all activities —
of this there is no doubt.

This is the second chapter, the chapter on the torma rite, from the Vajra Āraṇī.

Then the Blessed One gave the proper names in full:

With a long and elevated face,
likewise the wish-fulfilling tree,
the many who abide in the brahmic life —
to them at this samaya, grant the accomplishments.

An elephant, a horse, a she-yak's tail,
a lamp arising from a dog,
lighting a great lamp with these,
offer it to those who hold the brahmic life.

Then the vows were declared:

You shall slay living beings.
You shall also speak false words.
You shall take what is not given.
You shall resort to the women of others,
including one's own mother and sister,
one's own daughter and the daughter of one's sister —
through method and wisdom in their rite,
with yogic awareness, honor them always.

Then the empowerment was declared:

A master who holds the mudrā
shall confer the empowerment upon that one.
After that empowerment,
let this suchness be fully distinguished:
this suchness is great bliss,
abiding completely throughout the body.

This very thing is great gnosis,
whose intrinsic nature is supreme joy.

Then the fire offering was declared:

Dig into the earth to the measure of one cubit
and half a cubit in depth.

Let the skilled one make a fire pit
furnished with white powdered pigment.

With the mantra as it was taught,
perform the fire offering there of flesh and so forth.

Fire is the very eye of the gods,
and accomplishes every desired aim.

Then the maṇḍala was declared:

Four-cornered and four-gated,
adorned with four archways,
fully furnished with eight pillars —
let the skilled one draw the maṇḍala.
Charnel-ground charcoal, bones, pig,
as well as powder of red arsenic,
and likewise green powder —
these the skilled one praises for the maṇḍala.

In the centre, draw the vajra in three;
at the eastern gate, a great skull;
to the south, a vajra and bell;
likewise to the west, a battle-axe;
and to the north, an auspicious curved knife.

Draw this vajra maṇḍala.

For the aims of Dharma, for what is desired, and for liberation,
this maṇḍala is fully distinguished.

Having erected the maṇḍala,
the student is to be led into it.

Having bound the face with cloth,
it is removed and the maṇḍala is revealed.

This is the third chapter of the Vajrāraṇī — the chapter on all activities.

Then the supernatural knowledges (abhijñā) were declared:

The divine eye and the divine ear,
and likewise knowledge of others' minds,
recollection of former abodes,
and likewise the supernormal knowledge of miraculous powers —
if one meditates on the form of Heruka,
the yogin attains the five supernormal knowledges.
Through yoga practiced with great habituation,
one naturally becomes Heruka.
Having born power from meditative concentration,
one then undertakes the full conduct.
Whether the mind is steady or wavering,
in order to arouse one's own mind,
take up songs of many kinds
and likewise many kinds of dance;
perform varied rituals of service,
and varied ornaments upon the body;
and likewise the varied joyful
forms, sounds, and smells,
and tastes and objects of touch — fully engage them.

Then the extensive activities were declared:

Having drawn a grid of eight squares,
let the mantras of the tantra be laid out in full.
By the detailed distinction of the classes of activity —
pacifying, increasing, and the rest —
OM is for supremacy, in fire;
likewise it belongs to the sphere of truthlessness;
HŪṂ is at the junction of the wind.
To the east, JA abides distinctly;
to the south, the form of JA;
to the west, the form of BHYO;
to the north, the form of PHAṬ;
in the centre, SVĀHĀ abides distinctly.
On the three sides, the name of the thing to be accomplished.

This is the fourth chapter of the Vajrāralī — the chapter on conduct.

Then the drawing of the wheel was declared:

Strike down this great lady.
Bring this great lady under your power.
Make this great lady bewildered.
Make this great lady confused.
Consume her without remainder.
Make this great lady mute.
Summon this great lady.
Drive away this great lady.
Make this great lady feel hatred.
Bind this great lady.
Make this great lady infertile.
Make this great lady bent over.

These mantra-verses are written on both sides of a grain-winnowing fan and are to be inscribed with saffron on the underside of the fan's wing, and this is to be placed at the root of the target person's shoulder. For summoning, it is to be inscribed on cloth marked with the moon-sign and a lasso, using the juice of lac. For slaying and other such activities, charcoal from a charnel ground, the juice of chitraka, mustard oil, poison, and —

aconite, salt, the three pungent spices, the juice of kanaka, and a bone-pen. For summoning, a thorn of the emblic myrobalan plant is used. For bewildering, a stick of dhaṛuka wood. For exciting, a pen of pāṭa. For all activities without exception, one should write with a pen of bodhi-tree wood.

Then the Blessed One declared the Vajra Offering. He spoke:

At the border and in remote places,
and likewise within my own dwelling,
a girl of thirteen years
and likewise one of sixteen,
and one of twenty-five are to be worshipped.
A cow and likewise a mātā,
a young female animal, a female dog,
an ass, a female mule,
a doe, and a she-goat,
a pig and what comes from a lower animal —
if one worships Heruka with these,
there is no doubt that accomplishment will come.

The days of the fish and the transitions of the moon
are calculated by non-Buddhists (tīrthikas).

In order to purify defilement,
the yogin should experience them.

Living beings are not to be slain.

False words are not to be spoken.

What is not given is not to be taken.

Another's woman is not to be consorted with.

By day one rests; by night one rises,
and dwells in utterly even equipoise.

Great flesh and bone,
drinking great blood,
eating the great regenerative fluid,
and likewise the great Vairocana —
a brahmin woman and a servant woman,
a dancer and likewise a cook,
a woman wearing a skull and one who works with hides,
a caṇḍāla woman and likewise a sweeper,
a grass-seller and a butcher's woman,
and likewise a barbarian woman and others,
a potter and a beer-seller,
and furthermore one who is in her monthly flow —
a mother, a sister, a daughter,
a daughter born of a sister,
another's daughter is not to be abandoned.

One should not openly desire a woman of noble lineage.

Having always abandoned the woman one ought to go to,
the wise one should resort to the woman one ought not to go to.

This is the fifth chapter of the Vajrāralī, teaching the mechanical devices and
the mudrās of activity.

Then the Blessed One declared the setting down of the samaya vow. He
spoke:

The samaya vow is not to be set down
for śrāvakas of inferior fortune,
nor likewise for naked wanderers, those wearing skull-ornaments,
or any of those with matted hair.

If one is possessed of compassion oneself,
then one may do so.

Even one who has attained accomplishment but holds a lower view,
and a man born to benefit sentient beings
are declared to be of inferior fortune.

The brahmin opposes the samaya.

Then the Blessed One declared the samaya of the disciple. He spoke:

One who possesses a mind that tames others,
who is patient, composed, and not deceptive,
who is devoted to the guru and has compassion —
such a one is greatly praised in this tantra.

Then the Blessed One declared the characteristics of the master. He spoke:

One who knows the application of mantra and tantra,
who has compassion and is learned in treatises,
who fully knows the ten realities,
and who is skilled in the work of drawing maṇḍalas.

Then the Blessed One declared the consecration of the four sessions. He spoke:

By means of the practice of meditation as it is performed,
one consecrates the first session.

As long as that lasts until mid-morning,
at midday comes the third session.

Departing from time, at midnight
the consecration of sessions is fully renowned.

Through the consecration of sessions, the yogin,
through one's own practice endowed with yoga, attains accomplishment.

Then the Blessed One declared one's own maṇḍala. He spoke:

Attachment, aversion, and delusion,
envy and likewise miserliness —
in the Blessed One Heruka these are absent.

If they are present, that itself is the state of complete purification.

Then the Blessed One declared the accomplishment of the samaya. He spoke:

Whether upon a tree struck by obstacles or impaled,
or one hanging from a tree that is tied,
or one pierced by weapons in battle —
these are accomplished by oneself who is endowed with yoga.

Then the Blessed One declared the inner practice. He spoke:

Drinking the water of precious things,
whatever one eats thereby has meaning.
Ablution with boundless vajra —
bell and so forth in sequence — Vairocana performs.
One should practice likewise with the Dharma of samaya.

Then the Blessed One declared the vow. He spoke:

The vajra and bell are to be held,
and the nectar is to be consumed by the skilled one.
One should always rely upon one's own mudrā
and never transgress the conduct.

Then the Blessed One declared the offering to the deity. He spoke:

In a place by a river or in a forest grove,
one should worship the deity as oneself.
One should recite one's own mantra
and consecrate flowers and so forth.

This is the sixth chapter, teaching the various acts from the Vajra Āraḷī.

Then the Blessed One declared the alms bowl. He spoke:

The skilled one, with broken shoulder-straps,
should wander begging among the four classes.

Eat by the riverbank
and distinguish what is clean.

Take only a cat's-paw measure of liquid —
so an intelligent one should accept.

Do not take what is not given,
and always accept only what is freely offered.

Circumambulate those devoted ones to the right
and those who are hostile to the left.

Dwell in a household without fixed abode —
of this accomplishment there is no doubt.

Made hollow from vajra wood,

and likewise a bell of wood as its lord —
in order to perfectly accomplish Heruka,
grasp these and wander always.

Then the Blessed One declared the accomplishment of the vajra yakṣiṇī. He spoke:

Take a yellow arrow-shaft
and recite this mantra upon it.
Guard it, and having dried it,
mix it with bdellium resin.

A skilled one should offer fumigation with this
before the yakṣiṇī.

She is supremely beautiful and beautifully adorned —
her image, well-established in a painting, is for perfect accomplishment.

By this very rite,
one should summon the yakṣiṇī.

The painted image itself is the yakṣiṇī —
having received the offering first, she will depart.

All her ornaments —
whatever ornaments there may be —
should be taken as the prior offering.

If one desires, at night
worship her with flowers.

Then the Blessed One declared the accomplishment of the vajra zombie. He spoke:

One that is uncut, without wound, and whole —
one who possesses proper vows should wash it.

Anoint it with great butter
and fumigate it with great incense.

To the east of the great maṇḍala
offer a great butter lamp.

Whatever I have told you of this —
erect a maṇḍala in that place.

Strike the zombie with white mustard
and recite the syllables upon a mountain.

The skilled one should not be afraid of it.

Recite: Oṃ jvala jvala bhyo hūṃ.
It will then say: "What will you give me?"
The practitioner should accept from it
foot-ointment and eye-medicine,
a sword, an underground treasury,
pills, and the ability to travel through the sky —
all these it will bestow without doubt.

Then the Blessed One declared the feast maṇḍala. He spoke:

Having performed the meditation described above,
one should recite the mantra upon it.
Through the yoga of Heruka,
identifying oneself with him,
the feast maṇḍala will be accomplished.
In a place that is clean and solitary,
in a peaceful and virtuous spot,
the yogin should partake.
In this very feast maṇḍala,
of the glorious Heruka —

Now, the cooking: by equanimity of persons,
the samaya flavor is this:
whatever has the nature of song —
all ḍākinīs are the consort,
the sons are Mañjuśrī and the rest,
the wrathful ones are the service attendants,
and oneself becomes Heruka.

The recitation and repetition — correctly explained —
the mudrā is one's own limbs and so forth.

Visualizing the yoga of the deity,
who abides universally in all things —
what need is there to speak at length?

Whatever activity dwells in the world,
in order to attain the abode of Vajrasattva,
is made into a reversal of activities.

Such deeds as losing a mountain deer and so forth —
unknown in the world —
these come to be supremely celebrated.

One who is purely pure and supreme —
having attained that suchness, one practices perfectly.

The name called Āraṇī —
at Zabana, words should be spoken.
Dwelling at the head of the king of mountains,
surrounded by minds purified through the feast assembly.

And there too, within this maṇḍala of the feast assembly,
for the sake of whatever is to be accomplished right here,
one will not come to know accomplishment through mere offering.

The guardian of his queen
will become the terminator of Yama.

The terminator of wisdom is the protector of the host.

The terminator of the lotus is the lord guardian of the body.

The terminator of his obstacles —
this is spoken of as the general of the army.

The one called King of Desires
is himself the lord of his executioner.

The glorious one holding the blue club
is himself the lord who guards the door.

The one who exercises power over all,
swift and unmoving, is the protector himself.

The lord of the scribes
is likewise the greatly powerful one.

This is the seventh chapter of the Vajra Āraṇī: the chapter on accomplishing
siddhi.

Then, all the bodhisattvas led by Vajrapāṇi, upon hearing this teaching,
severed every bond of existence and became perfectly pure; their wrongdoing
was exhausted and their afflictions were burned away.

Then those bodhisattvas addressed these words: "Vajra Āraṇī, greatly diligent
— wondrous and marvelous in its variety! That which veils us with afflictions,
that which brings us to accomplishment!"

Then those bodhisattvas paid obeisance to the supreme among two-footed
beings, the most excellent, and proceeded to display the play of a buddha.
Some accomplish perfect awakening; some practice austerities; some appear
as emanations descended from the divine realms, and likewise those arising

from the womb; some turn the wheel of Dharma; some go forth into renunciation; some teach taming, with elevated mind upon elevated mind. Some bear the essence of mantra; some follow the way of the perfections; some follow the path of the Particularists (Vaibhāṣika); some appear as Sūtra-followers; some as consciousness alone (Vijñānavāda); some as Madhyamaka. Some go to the great hells; some care for sentient beings, tending after them. Looking upon the taming of sentient beings, they act with the intention of compassion.

This is the eighth chapter of the Vajra Āraṇī: the chapter on benefits.

Then all the Tathāgatas and all those bodhisattvas shall demonstrate the differentiation of actions. Whoever makes a sacred pledge in any tantra will be praised by all three worlds. Whenever one who possesses that tantra acts, they will become beautiful in existence.

Whoever makes offering through song
shall ever have a melodious voice.

For whoever offers a lamp,
they shall come to possess eyes.

Whoever makes offering through dance
shall become a great vidyādhara.

Whoever performs prostrations —
people shall prostrate to them.

Whoever offers sweet fragrance —
their body shall come to bear sweet fragrance.

Whoever offers fine garlands
shall come to possess golden garlands.

Whoever offers cloth
shall come to find the garments of the gods.

Whoever merely recites the name
and engages even with mere faith,
or cultivates especially fervent devotion,
or whoever makes offerings to persons —
all of those, through perfectly pure
means, shall have excellent enjoyment in existence.

This is the ninth chapter of the Vajra Āraṇī: the chapter on the praise of qualities.

Then again, whoever gives in this way, through such perfectly pure generosity, shall become supreme among two-footed beings. Then those bodhisattvas arose with joy intermingled with wonder, and having circumambulated the Blessed One three times, they sat nearby and asked: "What kind of yoga shall we practice?"

The Blessed One declared:

Generosity pure in all three spheres —

Heruka is to be meditated upon.

The act of giving too is Heruka;

likewise the recipient of the giving.

This generosity is supremely praised.

This generosity is but an example —

practice moral discipline and the rest in the same way.

Thus it was declared from the great king of tantras, the Vajra Āraṇī.

This completes the tenth chapter of the Vajra Āraṇī: the chapter on the unsurpassed yoga of the yoginī.

Translator's Notes

- The opening phrase "dwelling in the bhaga of the Perfection of Wisdom of all Tathāgatas" follows the stock Hevajra-cycle incipit: "bhaga" is left in transliteration as it is a technical tantric locution (the feminine generative symbol/source identified with the Perfection of Wisdom); rendering it otherwise would obscure the doctrinal point.

The "five mudrās," "five nectars," and "five meats" are standard antinomian Mahāyoga tantric referents whose specific contents are deliberately left implicit in the root tantra.

The "vows" section in the final portion is the well-known antinomian or transgressive samaya list found in many Mahāyoga tantras, where the five root precepts of lay Buddhism are inverted as tantric commitments. The passage presents these as esoteric instructions within the ritual-doctrinal framework of the tantra, not as ordinary ethical prescriptions.

The world-protector "with elephant-ear" (འཇམ་མཁའ་ལྷ་མོ་) may refer to a specific directional guardian figure; the reading is preserved literally as the referent is not definitively identified in the available commentarial material.

- The phrase rendered "sphere of truthlessness" for "bden bral nyid du" is technically "the state of being devoid of truth" or "the truth-free sphere," which in tantric context may refer to a particular mantra-body correspondence or a specific doctrinal category; its exact referent here is somewhat opaque and may belong to an oral commentary tradition no longer extant for this text.

The term "che ge mo" repeated throughout the wheel-drawing section is a Tibetan calque for a female target of the rite, here rendered "great lady," functioning as a placeholder term for the woman against whom these rites are directed. Some editions and commentators read it as a generic term of address.

- The passage is a dense ritual and antinomian text with several genuinely difficult points. The list of "great flesh," "great blood," and "great regenerative fluid" are standard Tantric coded references to the pañcamakāra (five nectars) or sacred transgressive substances used in Heruka-class practice; they are rendered literally as the text presents them. The phrase rendered "the woman one ought to go to" and "the woman one ought not to go to" reflects a deliberate antinomian reversal standard in such literature. The line "Vairocana performs" in the inner practice section is syntactically compressed and may alternatively mean that Vairocana is identified with the entire sequence; the reading adopted takes it as a completion of the ritual enumeration. The expression "days of the fish and transitions of the moon" likely refers to specific lunar dates; the tīrthika attribution suggests that the text is polemically distancing itself from the calculation method even while using it. The term rendered "bone-pen" translates a writing instrument made from bone, standard in such ritual contexts.
- The ordering of verses in this passage presents some structural complexity. The passage contains what appears to be a chapter colophon ("This is the sixth chapter, teaching the various acts from the Vajra Āraṇī") positioned mid-text, after which new material begins. The translation preserves this order faithfully.

The term rendered "yellow arrow-shaft" for 𐎧𐎡𐎴𐎠𐎧𐎺𐎠 is plausible — 𐎧𐎡𐎴𐎠 can mean yellow-grey or tawny, and 𐎠𐎧𐎺𐎠 refers to a dart or arrow-shaft — but the precise ritual object is uncertain.

• The names "Āralī" and "Zabana" are transliterations of what appear to be Sanskrit or prakrit terms functioning as place names or esoteric names within the tantra; their precise identification is uncertain. "Zabana" renders the Tibetan "za ba na," which may be a place name or a phonetic transcription of a Sanskrit toponym. This is noted as a potentially significant uncertainty for scholars but does not affect the overall sense of the passage.

The line "elevated mind upon elevated mind" renders "mngon pa'i sems ni lhag pa'i sems," a technical phrase distinguishing levels of intention or meditative mind; this may alternatively refer to "heightened resolve upon heightened aspiration," and the precise doctrinal nuance within this tantric context is genuinely uncertain.

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those

texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.